

want a browser that enables you to restrict access to sites with questionable content.

All five browsers provided 128-bit encryption. However, only Internet Explorer and NeoPlanet had a feature that allows you to set different levels for blocking Web sites containing sex, nudity, violence and profanity.

Mail client: An integrated e-mail client that allows you to download your e-mail and read it offline adds to the functionality of a browser. All five browsers in this category came with an e-mail client with sufficient options such as maintaining your contacts and creating separate folders for the different types of mail you get.

Outlook Express, which comes bundled with Internet Explorer, is known for its simple looks and functionality but is vulnerable to viruses that use Visual Basic scripting. The e-mail client in Netscape (both versions) and Mozilla (which uses the same e-mail client as Netscape) are safer on this front as they do not support VB scripting.

An interesting feature in NeoPlanet's e-mail client is the extremely friendly audio notification when a new mail arrives.

The older versions of Internet Explorer had an HTML editor, which was capable of some basic editing, but the newer version fails to provide one. Both versions of Netscape include a basic HTML editor, the 'Composer' for HTML editing.

Efficient downloads: Nothing can be more frustrating than having to start a download all over again because of disruptions in connection while downloading files over a dial-up. This is where download managers come in. They can be easily downloaded from the Net, but if the browser bundles one, it adds to the functionality.

Netscape 4.78, Mozilla and Internet Explorer do not seem have to understood this problem of most users and are yet to include this feature. Netscape 6.1 and NeoPlanet 5.2 have done their homework well and have made sure they include this almost mandatory feature.

One feature in NeoPlanet that needs special mention is the Modem Booster, which lets you tweak your Internet connection for maximum performance by changing the MTU settings (a parameter that optimises the bandwidth of the TCP/IP protocol).

Reducing the phone bills: Reading all those textually dense pages on the Net while online could be really expensive. Instead, use the offline-browsing feature if

Power Surfing

Does your Internet connection remind you of travelling by a bullock cart? Well, besides tweaking your connection settings, changing a few settings in your browser can also make it work faster.

Increase your cache size: Whenever you visit a Web site, the various elements of the site are stored in the disk cache. If you increase the cache size, more pages can be stored, thereby making it load faster. However, if you have a fast broadband connection, more cache can actually slow down the rendering of a page, since it takes more time to go through the cache than to download from the site. Also defragment your hard disk regularly. In Netscape 6 and Opera, you have

options for changing the memory cache too, so you can choose for more memory cache and lesser disk cache to improve performance.

Turn off Multimedia Features: If you are just browsing for textual information, disable the options for downloading images, sounds and animation.

Turn off Active X and Java: Most Web sites today use ActiveX and Java, which slow down the loading of Web pages and also make your browser consume more memory. ActiveX and Java can even be security hazards.

Smart Browsing: You can surf while simultaneously reading information on the Net by opening a new browser window. This saves a lot of time.

your browser supports it. Though Netscape 4.78 and its previous versions had this feature, you could not read pages offline by going to the history folder where all the Web pages visited are stored. Netscape 6.1, Mozilla, NeoPlanet and Internet Explorer allow you to do this.



Elegant looking MSN Explorer

Performance

To evaluate the performance of the browsers we ran ZD's iBench, which is a measure of the Web page rendering speeds, cache retrieval speeds and refresh speeds of an Internet browser. In this test various sets of HTML pages were loaded in loops and we noted down the time taken.

Internet Explorer was the fastest in loading and rendering pages. Netscape 6.1 and Mozilla took twice as long as Internet Explorer to load the pages and we couldn't see the pages while the browsers loaded and rendered them. Surprisingly, NeoPlanet took the longest to complete the test, even though it uses Internet Explorer's engine.

Since there are numerous Java-based applications on the Internet, a browser's

Java performance becomes critical. To test this, we ran Pen Dragon's Caffeine Mark 3.0. This test measures the different features of the JVM (Java Virtual Machine) and returns a score that roughly correlates with the number of Java instructions executed per second. In this test Mozilla failed to even load the Java applet in spite of downloading the Java plugin. NeoPlanet 5.2 topped by logging a score of 18510. Both the Netscape browsers performed quite poorly and Netscape 4.78 generated the lowest score amongst all the browsers in this category.

Function-specific browsers

In the second category of browsers we included those that offered certain specific functions. For instance, NetCaptor, Opera and Webhunter Power allow you to browse multiple Web sites in a single window, whereas MSN Explorer provides the facility of online storage and is also ideal for those who share their computers.

Speed and power

If you were to go by looks, then MSN Explorer beats just about every browser in this category. Its colourful interface and minimal buttons make it stand apart from others. NetCaptor 6.5, which uses Internet Explorer's engine, has an extremely simple interface with large buttons on the toolbar—it leaves a lot to be desired as far as looks are concerned. K-Meleon has the worst interface amongst them all. But there's more to browsers than looks. Users of Opera, NetCaptor and